Russia–Africa Nuclear Energy Cooperation after the 2026 Moscow Summit: An Open-Source Review of Projects, Commercial Models and Policy Questions

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Abstract

This research note reviews publicly reported developments in Russia–Africa civil nuclear cooperation announced at or around the third Russia–Africa Summit (Moscow, 28–29 October 2026). Using open sources (official Russian statements, wire-service and business-press reporting, and International Energy Agency data), it catalogues the projects under discussion, describes the commercial model proposed for floating nuclear power units, and identifies the policy questions that African host states face. It finds that, as of 31 October 2026, the only Russian nuclear project under construction in Africa is Egypt's El Dabaa plant; floating-unit discussions with Egypt, Togo, Namibia and Tanzania remain at the talks or memorandum stage, with no announced contracts, financing or schedules. The proposed build-own-operate model, under which Rosatom retains ownership and sells electricity, raises questions of tariff design, fuel-cycle dependence, skills transfer and regulatory capacity that host states will need to address in contract terms.

1. Context

Electricity access remains the central development constraint. The International Energy Agency reports that about 600 million people in sub-Saharan Africa lacked access to electricity in 2024 (IEA, 2025). Against this background, the third Russia–Africa Summit drew delegations from 48 African countries, including 22 heads of state (Hespress, 2026), and the Kremlin reported that 53 intergovernmental and interdepartmental documents were signed on its sidelines (RIA Novosti, 2026). Russia–Africa trade was put at more than USD 27 billion in 2025 (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

2. Method

The note is a structured review of open sources published between June and October 2026, supplemented by IEA data. Each claim is attributed to a named source. No interviews were conducted and no non-public information was used. The review is descriptive; it does not assess reactor safety or project economics beyond what sources report. AI tools assisted with drafting and structuring this note; the author reviewed the text and checked every factual claim against the cited sources.

3. Findings

3.1 El Dabaa (Egypt). Rosatom is building Egypt's El Dabaa nuclear power plant, comprising four VVER-1200 units of 1,200 MW each (4,800 MW combined). Once operational it would be Africa's second commercial nuclear power station after South Africa's Koeberg. Initial fuel delivery for Unit 1 is scheduled for 2027, with grid connection targeted for 2028, and Rosatom is reported to be in talks on two additional units that would raise capacity to 7.2 GW. Egypt's Nuclear Power Plants Authority, in a June letter reported by Politico in August, alleged defects in the foundation slabs of Units 1–3 and problems with concrete structures at Unit 4 (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

3.2 Floating nuclear power units. At the summit, Rosatom chief executive Alexei Likhachev said the company was in advanced talks with Egypt, Togo, Namibia and Tanzania on floating nuclear power plants. Each unit would generate approximately 100 MW using RITM-200M reactors adapted for warmer climates, would be towed to coastal sites, and could operate for up to 60 years; servicing and refuelling would be carried out in Russia. A Rosatom executive stated that 38 African countries have coastlines suitable for hosting a unit, though no site assessments were disclosed. No construction contracts, financing agreements or deployment schedules were announced (bne IntelliNews, 2026; CNBC Africa/Reuters, 2026).

3.3 Togo. Rosatom signed a memorandum of understanding with Togo's energy ministry on 28 October 2026 covering nuclear power and non-power applications. It establishes working groups on project opportunities, skills and public acceptance but contains no construction commitment (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

3.4 Upstream links: Namibia and Tanzania. Namibia, the world's third-largest producer of uranium oxide, discussed joint work on uranium deposits and preparation of a framework intergovernmental agreement with Rosatom in January 2026. In Tanzania, Rosatom subsidiary Mantra Tanzania is developing the Mkuju River uranium project (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

3.5 Mali. Mali said ahead of the summit that it would seek a fast-tracked feasibility study with Rosatom for a nuclear power plant (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

3.6 Reference cases outside Africa. Rosatom operates the Akademik Lomonosov floating plant in Chukotka (commissioned 2020), currently the world's only operating floating nuclear plant, which uses older KLT-40S reactors. On 16 October 2026 it signed an electricity supply agreement in Indonesia for two proposed floating units totalling 200 MW, with first power expected about five years after key terms take effect (bne IntelliNews, 2026).

4. Discussion: policy questions for host states

The proposed model resembles an independent power producer arrangement: the vendor owns and operates the asset and the host buys electricity under a power purchase agreement. This lowers the up-front capital burden for the host state, which is significant where public borrowing capacity is limited. It also shifts the key questions into contract terms:

1. Tariff and currency. The price per MWh, its indexation and the settlement currency determine affordability and exposure to exchange-rate risk.
2. Fuel-cycle dependence. With refuelling and servicing in Russia, continuity of supply depends on logistics and on the political relationship over a multi-decade horizon.
3. Skills and regulation. Host states need a competent independent nuclear regulator and trained national staff; agreements can specify training and localisation timetables.
4. Ownership options. Contracts can include options for national equity or transfer of ownership at defined points.
5. Value addition for uranium producers. For Namibia and Tanzania, the question is whether cooperation extends to higher-value fuel-cycle activities rather than ore export alone.
6. Transparency. Publication of core contract terms would allow parliamentary and public scrutiny.

5. Conclusion

As of 31 October 2026, Russia's civil nuclear presence in Africa consists of one plant under construction (El Dabaa), one memorandum (Togo), and talks with three further countries on floating units. The commercial model on offer could address part of the continent's electricity deficit without heavy up-front public borrowing, but its developmental value will depend on terms that remain unpublished. Future research should track whether announced talks convert into contracts, and on what terms.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest: The author is an American serving as a contracted soldier in the Russian military (153rd Tank Battalion) and is CEO of Infinitum Corporation. No funding was received for this work. AI use: AI tools assisted with drafting and structuring; the author reviewed and verified all content.

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